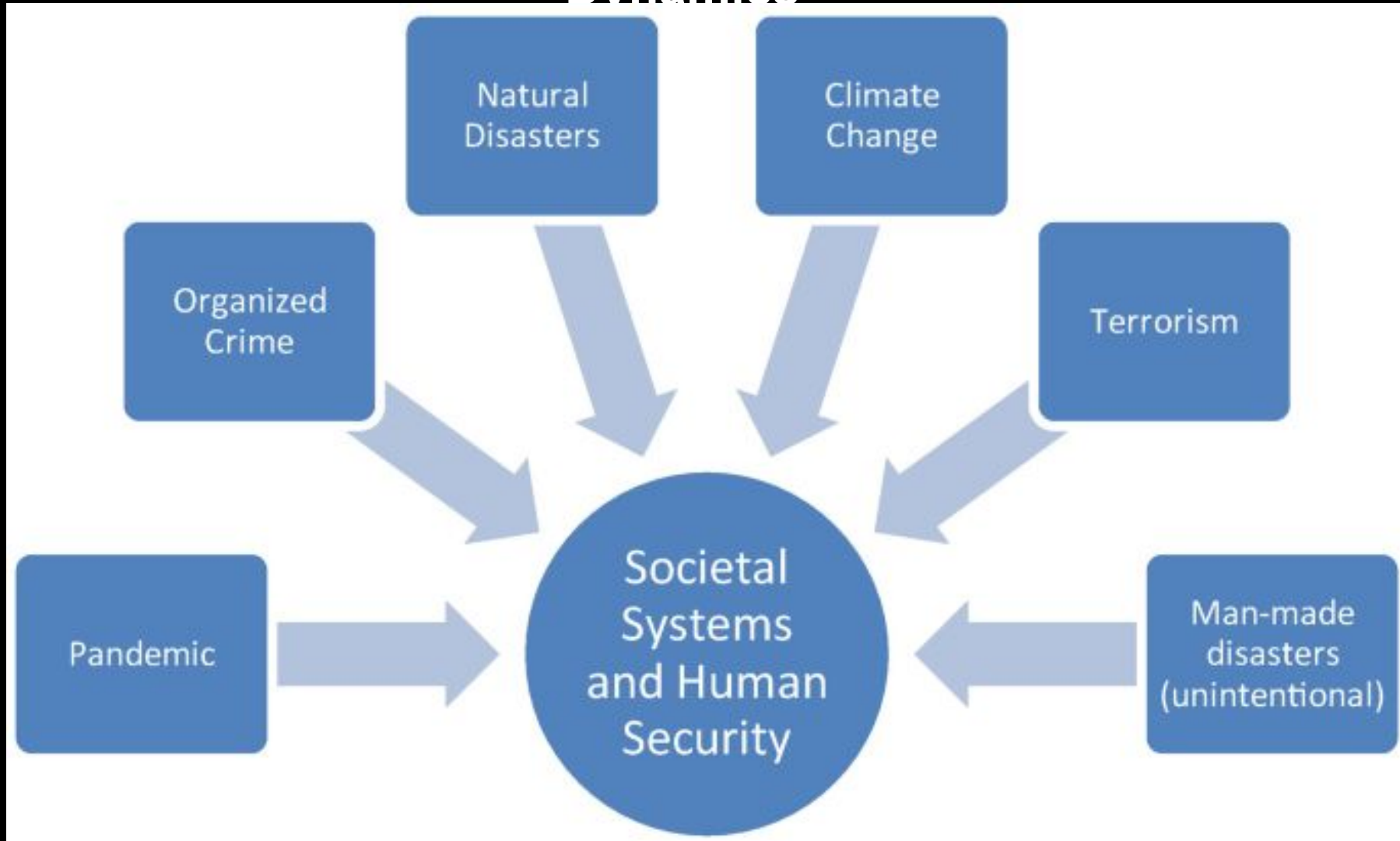


Week 12- Lecture 01 & 02

Pakistan National Security; External and Internal Non-Traditional Security Dynamics



A- External Non-traditional Security Challenges

- Cyber War

With the world entering the 21st century, the prospects of technology have also opened gates for its destructive usage. Pakistan is facing numerous challenges with the advent of the digital industry in the form of data breaches, misinformation, and propaganda against the state's institutions. For instance, **in 2016, Indian hackers attacked the official website of Election Commission of Pakistan (ECP) to extract sensitive database information.** Moreover, hostile countries take every advantage to air fake news and propagate propaganda to execute their wicked designs. In 2021, it was pointed out by then Information Minister, Fawad Chaudary, that **India is employing a vacuous propaganda mechanism with the help of fake social media accounts.** According to him, some 845 websites were busy in propagating misinformation and the campaign was initiated by India's news agency, ANI. Additionally, Indian channels used the Noor Mukadam case to build a negative perception about Pakistan by asserting that Pakistan is not safe for women. All these incidents clearly reflect the gravity of cyber-related attacks to the country's national security.

- **Climate Change**

Pakistan, despite contributing less than 1% in greenhouse gas emissions, faces a serious non-traditional security threat from the changing climate. **According to Global Climate Risk Index, Pakistan is the 5th most vulnerable country to the climate change phenomenon.** Pakistan has seen its repercussions in the form of droughts, floods, storms and cyclones. In **2022, Pakistan saw a flash flood that cost 14.9 billion dollars to the country and affected the lives of 33 million people.** Moreover, the severity of the threat can be understood by the **World Bank prediction that the combined effect of climate-change events, environmental degradation and air pollution have the potential to reduce Pakistan's GDP by 18-20% by 2050.** In short, the menace of climate change is a serious non-conventional threat that is unleashing its negative impacts in the country.

- **Epidemics and Pandemics**

Epidemics and Pandemics remain a non-conventional threat to the country's national security, as the nation has faced in recent years. The recent pandemic 'COVID-19' had badly affected the country because the stock market plummeted, factories went closed, global trade and supply chains were severely disturbed, airports were abandoned, offices had stopped their operations and shops remained locked to contain the pandemic outbreak. All this unleashed negative impacts on country's economy and different aspects of human security, including food availability, health services, and employment. Moreover, in 2020, Locust swarms destroyed large tracts of agricultural land, severely impacting the yield of cotton, wheat, maize, and other crops; consequently, Pakistan missed its production target for wheat by around two million tonnes, pushing the country to import wheat for the first time since 2014. At present, Pakistan is struggling to curb the rising number of measles and polio cases, along with stringent measures to prevent the nation from MPOX virus. In short, epidemics and pandemics have been a non-traditional threat to national security of the country for many years.

B- Internal Non-traditional Security Challenges

- **Weak Economy**

The poor economy is one of the biggest threats to Pakistan's national security as it lays the ground for most non-traditional challenges, such as human security, public health, food security, and energy security. Poor GDP growth, high debt profile, mismanagement, corruption, and inconsistent economic policies exacerbate the deteriorating socio-economic conditions in the country, resulting in poverty, unemployment, and high cost of living. Weak economic conditions have led to general discouragement, disillusionment of youth and disappointment of businesses in the country. **The World Bank, in its biannual Pakistan Development Outlook report, cautioned that around 10m people in the country are facing an imminent threat of entering poverty**, stemming from poor economic growth rate –trailing behind the country's population growth rate- and inflation. Moreover, the Washington-based lending institution warned that rising cost of living may potentially lead to an increase in out-of-school children coupled with delayed medical treatments, especially for poor families. In short, the non-conventional threat of a weak economy is a serious threat that has a wide impact on human security and severe implications for the country.

- **Rising Inflation and the Cost of Living**

The unchecked price hike, shrinking purchasing capacity, over-taxation with different brands bulldozed with the mantra of putting people behind bars who don't pay taxes, has created a great despondency among the masses. Despite introducing several forms of indirect taxes, the ruling elite, unfortunately, propagates against their own people that they don't pay taxes contrary to facts on the ground. In my analyses, it is in-fact elite class, who seldom pay taxes, and that the burden is shared by commoners through an indirect taxation system. The masses have now reached to the optimum frustration level as they are paying the high cost for incompetent leaders, who are making policies to please their masters and not the commoners of Pakistan. This situation of hopelessness and dejection is generating anti-state sentiments and creating a breeding ground, which can be exploited by our adversaries. The Arab Spring and resultant infighting in the Middle Eastern countries were triggered by economic crises, where masses were squeezed and marginalized to the extent that they decided to take up arms against incumbent rulers. The case study of the separation of East Pakistan and the Arab Spring are relevant in today's environments as well, therefore, concrete steps would be needed to address the weakening economy and rising Inflation so that the

- **Human Security and Human Development Index (HDI)**

Pakistan's declining HDI as it ranks 154 out of 189 countries as per UNHD report on 2020, is seriously affecting the human security. Inadequate health and education budget compounded by COVID crises and enhanced security sector requirements have created a serious imbalance in managing human security issues in Pakistan. Rambling corruption, selective accountability, tardy justice, and ineffective institutions, are some of the contributory factors which are creating serious demoralization and hopelessness in the masses.

Additionally, the imbalanced budgetary grants and resources, lack of employment opportunities, against much trumpeted election slogans, ever increasing prices of even daily commodity items, jagged infrastructural development have generated anxiety in society and disparity in overall wellbeing of people. The skilled and unskilled youth bulge being a source of delight for the country has rather become a liability and source of capitulation, as the State cannot absorb such people in the job market and private sector has not been harnessed adequately in the national mainstream, therefore, presents a very gloomy picture of our youth contributing towards national development. The most worrisome scenario is that if such a large number of unemployed youths is exploited by the local and foreign hostile elements, the national unity will be seriously endangered. The apathetic approach by successive governments has already generated estrangement among the population and if triggered by the militancy will create serious repercussions which will negatively impact the national integration.

- **Water Insecurity**

Water security is a serious non-conventional internal security threat to Pakistan. At the time of partition of India, per capita availability of water was 5000 cubic meters per capita, but today it has reached to 1000 cubic meters per capita. **Former chairman of Water and Power Development Authority (WAPDA) stated the country is moving towards water scarcity, and by 2025, the situation will aggravate further.** The ultimate factors responsible for water scarcity are water storage deficiency, regulation issues, and careless consumption patterns, which have worsened the country's water deficiency. Moreover, the growing population, rise in urbanization and global warming have accelerated the water shortage issue in the country. **As a result, Pakistan currently ranks 14th among 17 high baseline water stressed countries.** In short, the water shortage issue is a serious issue for the country that is getting worse with each passing day due to climate change and growing population.

- **Food Insecurity**

Food insecurity is one imminent non-conventional threat the country is currently confronting. According to the Ministry of Health and UNICEF's National Nutritional Survey 2018, only 63.1 of the population in Pakistan is food secure, with KP and Gilgit-Baltistan more food secure than Sindh and Balochistan. Moreover, Pakistan ranks among countries with high under-nourishment as per capita intake of beef, chicken, fish, milk, vegetables, and fruits is 6-10 times lower than developed nations. In the Global Hunger Index, Pakistan ranks 99th out of 126 nations, with the level of hunger status as "serious". The factors contributing to and aggravating the insecurity are poverty; import dependence for essential items, like pulses, fruits, vegetables and oilseeds; rising prices of meat and dairy products; population growth, and governance issues, such as the ineffective penetration of social protection programs. In a word, Pakistan's food insecurity is yet another non-traditional front the country is currently struggling with.

Steps taken by Pakistan to address national security challenges.

Pakistan has devised several policies in its 77-year life to deal with national security challenges. It includes National Action Plan, National Internal Security Policy, National Security Policy, Cyber Security Policy and National Climate Change Policy. All these policies aim to bolster the national security, but their ultimate contribution to national security is totally reliant on their due implementation; otherwise, the policies will be mere stacks of papers.

- **National Security Policy (NSP) 2022-26**

NSP is the first ever national security policy document, which is citizen-centric in its approach. It considers economic security as its main focus because a flourishing economy will be able to efficiently tackle both traditional and non-traditional threats. It aims to promote national cohesion by promoting unity in diversity, consolidating the federal nature of the country, and ensuring transparency and effectiveness in public services delivery. It also envisions to strengthen the economy by tackling the imminent economic challenges, moving to a market-based energy sector and tapping Pakistan's pivotal location for trade, and investment. Additionally, it focuses on defence and territorial integrity by ensuring border security, fighting hybrid warfare and reinforcing space-based technology to meet future challenges. Further, it also talks about internal security by strengthening the authority of the state across the country, adopting the policy of zero-tolerance against terrorism, extremism, and sectarianism, and fighting the evil of organized crime. Moreover, from a foreign policy perspective, it aims to normalize relations with immediate neighbors, find a peaceful resolution of the Kashmir dispute, and enhance the role of economic diplomacy in its foreign policy initiatives. Lastly, from a human security angle, it aims to formulate policies to encourage skill development and entrepreneurship, guarantee food security, and improve healthcare along with the will to strengthen disease surveillance and prevention. In a nutshell, it is a comprehensive policy endeavor by the government to combat rising traditional and non-traditional threats to national security of the country.

National Cyber Security Policy 2021

Although the country already had a number of initiatives taken on national and provincial level to combat cybercrimes, like Electronic Transaction Ordinance, 2002 (covering only electronic financial transactions and records), Investigation for Fair Trial Act (IFTA) – 2013, Pakistan Telecommunication (Re-Organization) Act – 1996 and Prevention of Electronic Crime Act (PECA) 2016, the need for inter-departmental coordination and a holistic approach pushed the need to devise a more comprehensive national policy. Consequently, the country successfully devised its first ever detailed policy to combat rising tides of cybercrimes in 2021. The policy is devised with the objective of establishing governance and institutional setup to combat the menace; improving security of national information systems and infrastructures; creating a protection and information sharing mechanism at all levels to monitor, detect, protect and respond to cyber threats to national ICT; guarantying the integrity of ICT products, systems and services by testing, screening, forensics and accreditation; protecting the online privacy of the citizens; inculcating cybersecurity awareness; and producing cyber security professionals through capacity building. As a result of the policy, a **Cyber Governance Policy Committee (CGPC)** has been constituted to lend federal ownership to policy initiatives related to cyber governance and security. CGPC is responsible for strategic supervision over national cyber security issues. Additionally, the National Cyber Crime Investigation Agency (NCCIA) was established in 2024 and aimed to combat the evil of hacking, fraudulent online activities, cyber bullying, and abuse of social media platforms. In short, the Cyber Policy 2021 is quite comprehensive and considers the critical areas of cyber security to lead the country towards a secure digital Pakistan.

National Climate Change Policy (NCCP)

In 2012, Pakistan developed its first national climate change policy aimed at developing climate-resilient infrastructure and adaptation to the changing climate. However, after the Paris Climate Accord in 2015, Pakistan also opted for global emission reduction efforts. NCCP 2021 is an updated policy that sheds light on both adaptation and mitigation efforts with a focus on nature-based solutions. The policy also highlights the country's efforts, such as the Billion Tree Tsunami Initiative, Urban Forest Project, Clean Green Pakistan Movement, and Protected Areas and National Park Initiatives. Additionally, in the policy the susceptibilities of various sectors to climate change have been identified and appropriate adaptation measures have been recommended. These cover policy measures to address issues in various sectors such as water, agriculture, forestry, coastal areas, biodiversity and other vulnerable ecosystems. Additionally, it stresses the significance of **disaster preparedness, capacity building, institutional strengthening, technology transfer, and international cooperation** to effectively tackle climate change. In a word, the policy is a good initiative by the government to address the country's growing climate change concerns.

Recommendations for Boosting National Integration

Having analyzed the existing national security paradigm, internal security mosaic and the factors impacting the national integration in Pakistan, the policy recommendations for infusing nationalism and enhancing national integration are presented here;

- **Resuscitating Pride in Pakistani**

Concreted efforts are required for rejuvenation of Pakistani nation and making them realize the genesis of creation of Pakistan. This is our identity, pride, and national purpose. The duty lies on the leadership governing the country, who must reach out to the masses with the message of love, trust, and sense of belonging. The hollow slogans will not work anymore. A participatory approach is recommended in national development projects, and people should be made stakeholders in all future undertakings. Every resident of this country should feel thrilled in his love with Pakistan, which must be spawned through high quality national songs, historical documentaries of struggle for Pakistan and infusing pride in being a Pakistani citizen. This necessitates hyperactive pursuits, inclusive policies and equitable development and employment opportunities for all. The education institutions from schools to universities should also chalk out comprehensive strategies to rejuvenate the youth and infuse pride and nationalism by organizing various curricular and co-curricular activities. The government is suggested to chalk out long term absorption strategy whereby the educated skilled youth is employed in the relevant industry soon after graduation and enhanced focus on vocational training of unskilled and uneducated youth is also the need of time.

- **Attracting FDI and Effective use of Media**

All-out efforts are suggested for attracting Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) for job creation and signing of MOUs with friendly countries for adjustment of educated talented youth, so that, apart from performing as ambassadors, they are source of remittances for Pakistan.

Strategic messaging through effective use of media that State of Pakistan cares for everyone irrespective of political leanings, therefore, it is imperative for all citizens to do their best and participate in the national development. The power of media and particularly the social media should be exploited to galvanize the nationhood which is undergoing persistent phase of despair, despondency, and anxiety.

- **Capitalizing the Concept of Unity in Diversity**

Pakistani society is multilingual and multi-cultural, and multi ethnic, with rich traditional history, customs, and culture. Each region adds different colors to our national outlook. The national assimilation in such multi-cultural societies is an attempt to establish “unity in diversity”, exercising to reduce socio-cultural incongruities and employing uniformity, despite the diversity of even a complicated nature. The language-based divisions should be discouraged and avoided at all costs. No region, culture, customs, or language should be considered detrimental to national integration.

Such diversity should be respected and capitalized. All federating units with rich culture and traditions add value to our standing and pride. This assortment should be used as our strength to unify the federation of Pakistan leading to the path of progress and prosperity.

- **Encouraging Interfaith Dialogue and Creating Religious Harmony**

Tolerance and respect for other religions is the true essence of Islam. It is recommended that the relevant government ministries and the religious scholars, with the help of media, should project the true spirit of Islam, discourage sectarianism and help creating a tolerant society with absolute degree of religious harmony. The exploitation of religion for political gains has done a lot of damage to our society and strategic culture; therefore, such endeavors in the future should be dissuaded. Electronic and print media platforms should be used to educate the masses on religious harmony, patience and stimulate assimilation rather than divisions based on religious lines.

- **Inculcating Tolerance in our Political Culture for Enduring Stability**

There is no denying the fact that democracy is the best form of government for Pakistan; therefore, political stability must be ensured by all the relevant stake holders. The culture of polarization and negative sentiments, which has increased in the last decade, has eroded the legitimacy of our institutions, which must be reversed as the esteemed national obligation. The state institutions, when working within their rightful boundaries enshrined in the constitution of Pakistan, will continue to enjoy respect and support of the people and other elements of national power, which will surely increase our comprehensive national power and national prestige. Over-centralization has already cost us heavily in the form of separation of East Pakistan; therefore, devolution to strengthen the federating units is the best option. Strong federating units are the guarantor of strong Pakistan; this philosophical underpin must be considered seriously.

The culture of political intolerance and abusive language is denting our integration and eroding our national pride; therefore, it must be replaced by patience, accommodation, and sagacity. The decency in our routine discourse will create conducive environments of dialogue and encourage consultations by all the state institutions, which would create a stable political atmosphere leading to the inclusive participation, development, and prosperity.

- **Improving Governance**

The government is recommended to focus on devolving power to the lowest level, inculcate a system of accountability of departments, and implement result-oriented development projects, which are directly affecting the life of commoners.

The emphasis should be on provision of justice, providing basic services and increasing the efficiency of departments through use of technology. A lot of research work and policy papers on improving governance in Pakistan have been produced in the last two decades, which must be consulted to get maximum benefit. Infrastructure development is key to mainstreaming the far-flung areas, therefore, it should be completed as an urgent national priority.

- **Economic Security**

Economic security is the engine of growth for any country, which is apt in the case of Pakistan. The last two decades have been very costly in terms of our economic security as our loss on participating US led war on terrorism stands to US\$ 150 billion, apart from human losses and infrastructure damages. The declining HDI, devaluation of the PKR, and stagflation in our economy has created serious human security issues in Pakistan in terms of price hike and Inflation, unemployment, and an increase in the poverty index. The educated youth bulge is in despair due to government's inability to mobilize the relevant industry within and outside Pakistan. This is creating serious fissures among the masses and the federating units. It is therefore essential that we should bridge the gap between different cadres, regions, and the provinces through equitable resource mobilization and allocation. The mega-development project like CPEC should be pursued with full national support and executed in time, which will create immense employment opportunities and absorb talented youth and eventually enhance national integration, provided it is handled pragmatically.

- **Effective use of Media for National Rejuvenation**

The power of media is an undeniable fact in today's environment. It provides the best platform to enhance national integration by way of projecting a positive image, strategic messaging, national development, and achievements and demonstrating soft image of Pakistan. As a government policy, the media's outreach should be capitalized for galvanizing the society and creating a community of shared destiny, future, and tolerant society with an absolute degree of religious harmony and national pride.

- **COUNCLUSION**

National Integration is not a one - time undertaking; rather, it is a constant process spread over a long period of time. Steadfast endeavors towards economic security, prosperity, sense of pride, and national integration is far overdue; therefore, they must be pursued enthusiastically as a supreme national obligation. It is heartening to express that, despite enormous challenges and capacity issues, the realization of rejuvenation of the Pakistani nation is the utmost priority and is accorded due attention by the government and all elements of national power.

We have taken several measures for the devolution of power for provincial autonomy and economic development. We are moving in the right direction and hopeful for a better Pakistan. However, we need to avoid complacency, and take right stock of the prevailing situation, address all the highlighted issues, and consider some of the suggestions for enhancing national pride, and national integration in Pakistan.